AUTOMATIONS · FOR STARTUPS

5

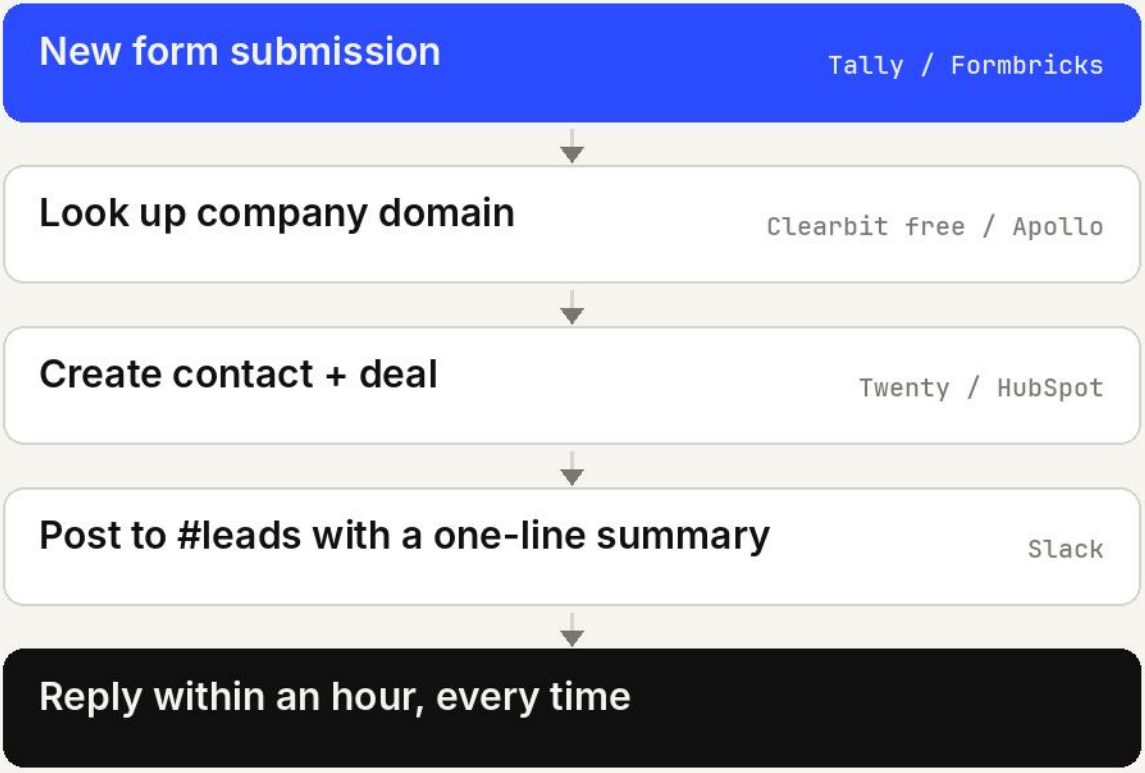
automations we'd have running by month three

Not the fancy ones. The five that stop small things falling through the cracks.

Each one is six nodes or fewer in n8n, Make or Zapier. Build time is an afternoon each if you've done one before, a weekend if you haven't.

1 · LEAD INTAKE

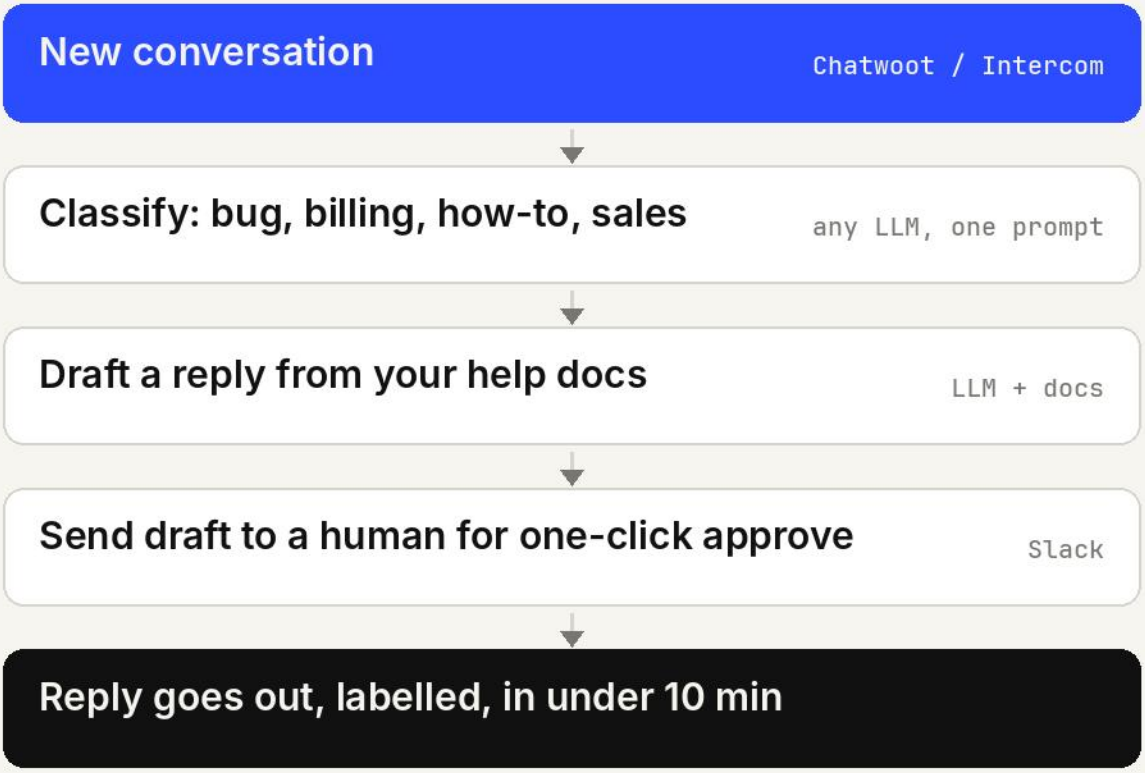
Every form fill becomes a CRM record and a Slack ping, with the company looked up



The win isn't speed. It's that nobody has to remember to check the form inbox.

2 · SUPPORT TRIAGE

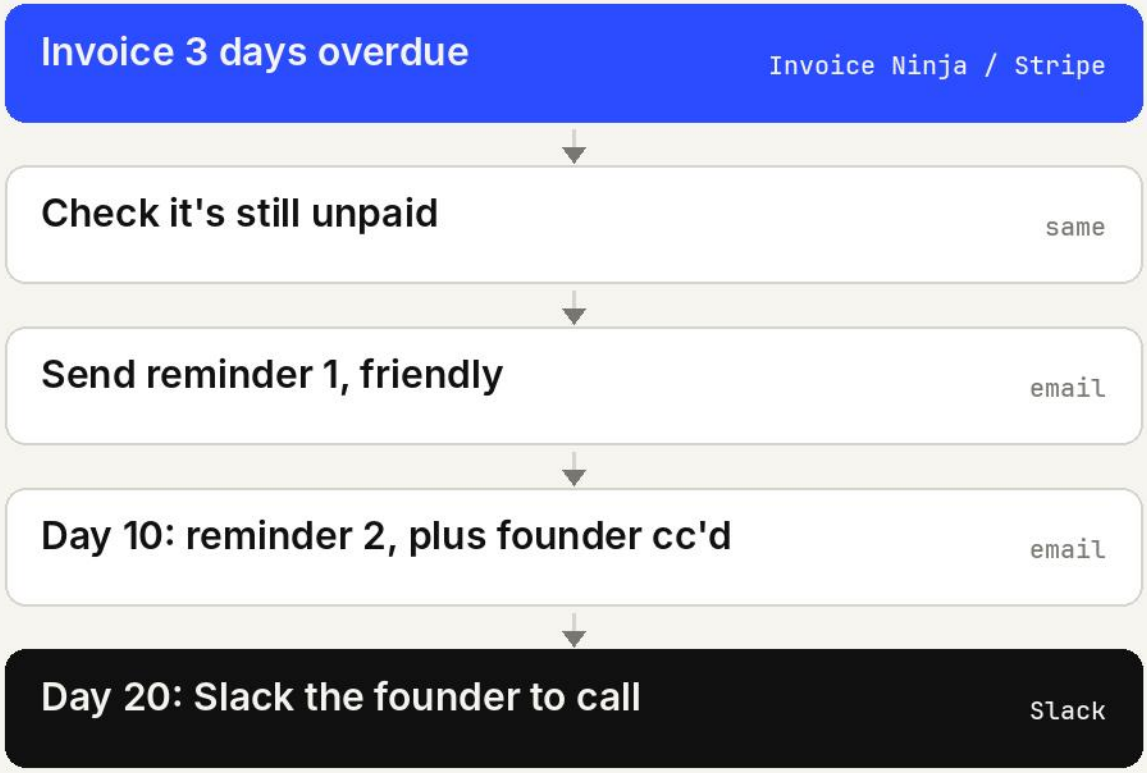
Tickets get sorted before a human reads them



Keep the human approve step for at least a month. Then look at what they never edit.

3 · INVOICE CHASING

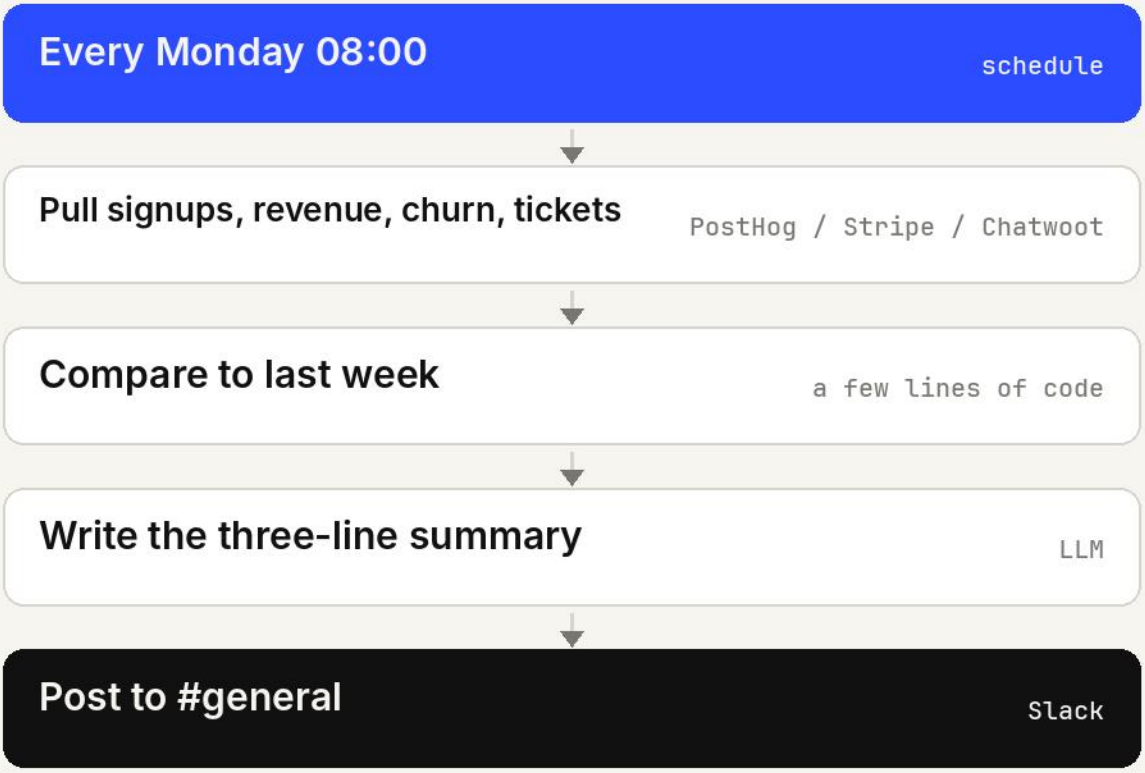
Unpaid invoices chase themselves, politely



Most late payments are forgotten, not refused. The first reminder clears half of them.

4 · WEEKLY NUMBERS

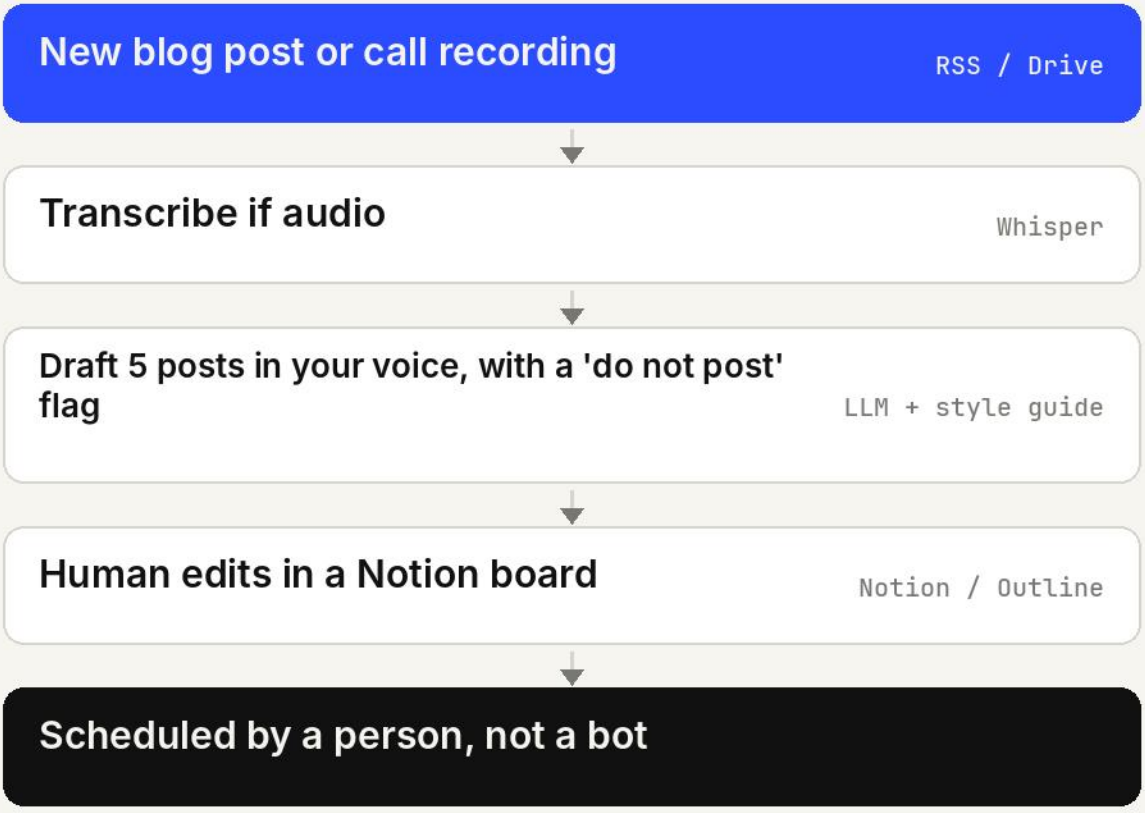
Monday 8am, the numbers arrive before anyone asks



If the summary ever says 'everything is fine', fix the prompt. Something is never fine.

5 · CONTENT REPURPOSING

One long thing becomes five short things



The bot drafts. A person decides. The posts that skip the person are the ones readers flag as slop.

WHICH TOOL FOR THE PLUMBING

n8n vs Make vs Zapier, for a startup

	Zapier / Make	n8n
Running in 10 minutes	✓	–
Free tier that covers five automations	–	✓
Self-host, own the data	–	✓
Bill grows with runs	✓	–
Someone else keeps it up	✓	–
AI agent nodes built in	✓	✓

If nobody on the team has run Docker, start on Make. Move to n8n when the bill makes you wince.

THE RULE WE KEEP COMING BACK TO



Automate the thing you've done by hand twenty times. Not the thing you imagine doing.

— Lean Stack

Which of the five would you build first?

Tell us in the comments. The most-requested one gets a full node-by-node build next week.

Follow Lean Stack